separately in early 1988. Individually, each agreed that they needed a faster and more sophisticated army of insurgents to mount a coordinated attack on the Najibullah government.

Meanwhile, Soviet troops began withdrawing from Afghanistan in May 1988, after the Geneva Accord signed by the Soviet Union, the USA, Pakistan and Afghanistan. But the war was far from over. Pakistan was still not ready to accept the interim government of Na-jibullah and Zia gave Gul complete freedom to prepare a strong force of mujahideen. Though Zia died on 17 August 19 8 8 in a Hercules C-13 0 crash near Bahawalpur, his death only slowed Pakistan's plan to depose the Najibullah government, it did not end it. According to Ash-faq, after Benazir Bhutto came to power as prime minister of Pakistan in the first week of December 1988, Gul convinced her to continue the operation.

'Gul told her that since the withdrawal of Soviet troops the insurgents had captured major Afghan provinces, so if a Pakistan backed operation was launched quickly, the Afghan regime would fall to its knees. He was correct to say that the insurgents had captured Takhar, Paktika, Bamiyan and some border areas as well, but the Afghan forces trained by the Soviets were fighting to the hilt. Gul was asked by Benazir to move slowly and wait for the total sanitisation of Soviet troops from Afghan soil,' Ashfaq told me.

The R&AW spies revealed that in late February 1989, Benazir Bhutto and Gul decided to capture Jalalabad city to establish the sevenparty alliance government. The idea was to make Jalalabad the capital of the government of the holy warriors.

'We forewarned Najibullah's government and shared a report with the Afghan army which noted that about six thousand